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An exploration of consumers' experiences in physical stores: comparing consumers' and retailers' perspectives in past and present time

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ABSTRACT
In this paper, we explore consumers' in-store experiences and their components, from both a consumer and retailer perspective. This is a replication of a study we performed in 2006 and thus we also examine how the role of the physical store has changed over the last decade. We use the *Critical Incident Technique* (CIT) to improve our understanding of consumers' in-store experiences. Moreover, we conduct in-depth interviews with Swedish retailers to achieve an understanding of how retailers use aspects of the store environment to enhance the consumer experience. Interestingly, our results suggest that consumers' in-store experiences to a large extent are created by the same aspects today as ten years ago (e.g. personnel, layout, atmosphere). Furthermore, while retailers today emphasize the importance of fulfilling new and more advanced consumer demands, they often still accentuate the weight and use of traditional values (e.g. personnel and layout) ahead of advanced technology.

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Introduction

The physical retail store operates in a transforming environment. Today, many consumers use multiple retail channels when shopping and the use of smartphones in shopping contexts is increasing (e.g. Kushwaha and Shankar 2013; Pantano and Priporas 2016). As a result of the new channels, consumers have developed new shopping activities – both in terms of their decision and search processes, and their ways of approaching retail stores. Research on multichannel retailing shows that such changes have major impact on consumers' shopping activities as well as how retailers organize their offerings (e.g. Godfrey, Seiders, and Voss 2011; Jones and Runyan 2013; Kollmann, Kuckertz, and Kayser 2012; Venkatesan, Kumar, and Ravishanker 2007). Researchers and consulting companies alike have formulated updated models of the shopping process with relevance to the twenty-first century (e.g. Ashman, Solomon, and Wolny 2015; Edelman and Singer 2015a, 2015b; Puccinelli et al. 2009; Vázquez et al. 2014), but often these new models lack empirical backing.

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It is safe to assume that increasing consumer contact with new channels besides the physical store will result in new consumer reference frames (e.g. Björn and Johansson 2014; see also Ericsson 2012, 2013). Recent research suggests an accumulated importance for retailers to create store environments that enhance positive experiences for in-store consumers (e.g. Bagdare 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Spence et al. 2014; Stein and Ramaseshan 2016). The physical store is undoubtedly facing changes – both from a consumer and a retailer point of view – but our knowledge of what this will imply is still limited.

In retail research, considerable attention has been devoted to consumers' experiences and their components. Scholars have described various in-store aspects that conceptualize consumers' experiences (e.g. Grewal, Levy, and Kumar 2009; Puccinelli et al. 2009; Verhoef et al. 2009) and examined the effect of such aspects on in-store behaviors and experiences (e.g. Andreu et al. 2006; Babin, Hardesty, and Suter 2003; Baker et al. 2002; Eroglu, Machleit, and Chebat 2005; Mattila and Wirtz 2001). Over the years, such research has often been based on a stimulus-organism-response perspective (cf. Mehrabian and Russell 1974), in which the focus is placed on the effect of a small number of variables. In more recent years, scholars have emphasized the need for new approaches when examining consumers' in-store retail experiences. Some have, for example, stressed an holistic approach of studying consumers' experiences (Ballantine, Parsons, and Comeskey 2015; Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Yoon 2013), and the need for devoting attention to the store environment as subjectively experienced by consumers (e.g. Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015). Still, there is a lack of research that places consumers' subjective experiences at the center of attention. Moreover, we need to enhance our understanding of how retailers relate to consumers' in-store experiences, in particular in a situation as the present when the physical retail store faces changing conditions.

This article explores consumers' in-store experiences and their components, taking perspectives of both consumers and retailers into consideration. We examine experiences of in-store consumers from three different lines of questioning and find research contributions as follows:

Firstly, this article enhances our understanding of how consumers' in-store experiences are constituted. *What aspects of the store environment contribute in forming consumers' (positive and negative) experiences? How do these aspects form consumers' experiences in this setting?*

Secondly, we advance our understanding of how retailers relate to consumers' experiences in the physical store. *How do retailers of today design and organize their store environments to enhance consumers' in-store experiences?* And moreover, *to what extent is there a match between consumers' preferences and retailers' performances?*

Finally, this article also provides insights into the changing role of the physical store over time as it replicates an article published a decade ago (see Bäckström and Johansson 2006), in which we also studied in-store experiences from both a consumer and a retailer perspective. Using results from that study, we can compare the role of the physical store today and how it has changed during the years that have passed: *What kind of new retail offerings are consumers of today seeking in the physical store? What does this imply for retailers in terms of new opportunities and challenges*?

The structure of the paper is organized thus: We begin by describing the theoretical framework used in this study, providing an overview of traditional store aspects often referred to in research on consumers' in-store experiences, as well as a discussion on

important developments in this field over the last ten years. Then follows a methodological discussion, in which we describe what methods we have used and how our analysis is conducted. Thereafter we present the results, including how in-store experiences are viewed by both consumers and retailers, as well as comparisons between the two. Finally, we provide our conclusions and propose suggestions for further research.

Consumers' experiences in the physical store

Within retail research, the issue of how consumers' in-store experiences are composed has been studied by many and for long. A number of scholars have presented conceptual frameworks focusing particularly on outlining the dimensions that influence consumers' experiences in retail store settings (e.g. Baker et al. 2002; Grewal, Levy, and Kumar 2009; Puccinelli et al. 2009; Verhoef et al. 2009). This literature has provided wide-ranging descriptions of various aspects that contribute in creating in-store experiences, referring to *consumer aspects* (e.g. goals, attitudes, and involvement) (Puccinelli et al. 2009; Verhoef et al. 2009); *retail aspects* (e.g. design, atmospherics, social aspects, service, and price) (Baker et al. 2002; Grewal, Levy, and Kumar 2009; Puccinelli et al. 2009; Verhoef et al. 2009); *situational aspects* (e.g. store type, season, and culture) (Verhoef et al. 2009); as well as *macro-level aspects* (e.g. economic and political aspects) (Grewal, Levy, and Kumar 2009). However, more empirical investigations on what roles such aspects have in defining consumers' in-store experiences are still needed.

Nevertheless, building on conceptualizations provided by Baker (1987) and Bitner (1992), a long line of researchers have improved our understanding of how various store aspects influence consumers' in-store experiences and behaviors (e.g. Andersson et al. 2012; Andreu et al. 2006; Baker et al. 2002; Eroglu, Machleit, and Chebat 2005; Hynes and Manson 2016; Wakefield and Baker 1998). In particular within research on consumers' experiences, atmospheric aspects have received much attention. The overall role of store atmospherics has been studied (e.g. Babin and Attaway 2000; Bagdare 2013; Ballantine, Jack, and Parsons 2010; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Turley and Milliman 2000) as well as the effects of specific atmospheric cues such as music (e.g. Hynes and Manson 2016; Jain and Bagdare 2011; Morin, Dubé, and Chebat 2007), color (e.g. Babin, Hardesty, and Suter 2003; Bellizzi and Hite 1992), and scents (e.g. Hultén 2012; Madzharov, Block, and Morrin 2015; Michon, Chebat, and Turley 2005). However, previous research concerned with the effect of atmospheric aspects may also be subject to criticism. For example, such studies are often based on a stimulus-organism-response perspective (cf. Mehrabian and Russell 1974) where the researcher's understanding of central concepts are in the forefront. In their review of research on ambient scents, Teller and Dennis (2012) question the robustness of such research findings and emphasize that this type of research does not sufficiently take into account the role of moderating variables such as consumers' own perceptions and their previous experiences (Teller and Dennis 2012). Following these arguments, there is need for research that focus on consumers' descriptions of their in-store experiences and aspects that contribute in forming them.

In earlier research on the impact of store environments on consumers' experiences, aspects such as those referred to above have been most salient. Though that is partly still the case, researchers have lately begun to shift emphasis onto other dimensions, a development that is discussed further in the following section.

Consumers' experiences in physical stores: the need for a new theoretical framework

The starting-point for the study we conducted roughly ten years ago (Bäckström and Johansson 2006) was the increasing attention of the role of consumer experiences among academics and practitioners alike (cf. Pine and Gilmore 1999; Schmitt 1999). Since then, the interest for exploring consumer experiences has not faded, rather the contrary. In recent retailing literature, there are frequent references to the need of more knowledge on consumer experiences (Bagdare 2013; Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Spence et al. 2014; Stein and Ramaseshan 2016), and some even mean this will bring about a 'new experiential paradigm shift' (Sachdeva and Goel 2015, 290). To further explore how consumers' in-store experiences are created and formed thus remains an important task. A closer look at how consumers' in-store experiences have been studied and discussed more recently reveals certain important differences compared to earlier studies, as regards both emphasis on specific store dimensions and applied research approach in such studies. Most specifically, when it comes to conceptualizations of the store environment, in our previous framework (Bäckström and Johansson 2006) we particularly emphasized aspects such as those referred to above (e.g. atmospherics, design, and social aspects) (c.f. Baker, Grewal, and Parasuraman 1994; Bitner 1992). Taking more recent research into consideration, it is apparent that such a framework is no longer sufficient, neither to describe *what* different store aspects that contribute in forming consumers' experiences, nor to account for *how* consumers experience and interact with such settings. In the sections below, we discuss how research on consumers' in-store experiences has developed during the last decade, referring particularly to three major themes.

Firstly, there is a growing tendency for scholars to emphasize the benefits of using *holistic* and/or *multisensory* approaches when studying in-store experiences (e.g. Ballantine, Parsons, and Comeskey 2015; Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Spence et al. 2014; Verhoef et al. 2009; Yoon 2013). For example, Verhoef et al. (2009, 32) argue that 'the customer experience construct is holistic in nature and involves the customer's cognitive, affective, emotional, social and physical responses to the retailer'. In line with this, it has been argued that creating positive in-store experiences is much about handling multiple dimensions (e.g. emotional as well as rational dimensions), and about recognizing the subjective nature of consumer experiences (e.g. Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Spence et al. 2014; Yoon 2013). Yet, while the multidimensional nature of in-store experiences and the various store aspects that form such experiences are increasingly more researched and better understood, there is still a want of empirical investigations.

Secondly, questions of how to organize *physical store concepts* are also addressed in more recent research. The growth of multichannel retailing has brought forth new conditions for retailers and according to some researchers, the physical store as a concept will need to change (Agnihotri 2015; Bell, Gallino, and Moreno 2014; Björn and Johansson 2014). New ways of organizing the physical store are proposed and evaluated; for example as 'showrooms' (Bell, Gallino, and Moreno 2014) or 'click-and-collect' concepts (Chatterjee 2010). Implementation of such novel store concepts will likely have significant impact on consumers' in-store experiences. More precisely how and in what ways this will come about is scarcely

investigated empirically, neither how consumers perceive of such developments, nor how such changes are viewed from a retailer perspective.

Thirdly, the implementation of various *technological solutions* has of late been referred to as an important competitive retailer advantage, both in handling competition from other channels and in creating positive customer experiences (e.g. Blázques 2014; Dennis et al. 2012; Poncin and Mimoun 2014). For example, researchers have described digital signage as an 'atmospheric tool' that may affect both consumers' in-store experiences and behaviors (Dennis et al., 2012, 2014). Moreover, self-service technologies are today a common part of retail settings and influence how store environments are experienced by consumers (Demoulin and Djelassi 2016; Lin and Hsieh 2011). Smartphone usage by consumers in-store is another technological advancement considered to be an important element of today's stores (Shankar et al. 2010; see also e.g. Tseng and Yazdanifard 2015). Research has shown that the smartphone influences how consumers interact with both the physical store environment and salespeople, for example by making consumers more distant and less reachable (Fuentes, Bäckström, and Svingstedt 2016). Hence, compared to ten years ago, the technological dimension has developed into a new and important element of retail store environments.

While previous research has improved our understanding of the various store aspects that create consumers' in-store experiences, there is a need for research into *how* such aspects contribute in forming subjective experiences. Moreover, there is also a need to advance our comprehension of specific technological aspects, both with regard to how such aspects shape in-store experiences and how retailers use and relate to them. By studying perspectives of consumers as well as retailers, we here provide new insights into these subjects.

Methodology

Our approach in this study is qualitative and rests on two different kinds of empirical material. Using the *Critical Incident Technique* (CIT) (Flanagan 1954), we explore written descriptions of consumers' own in-store experiences. The CIT is a method in which content data analysis is conducted on subjects' descriptions of certain incidents (Bitner, Booms, and Tetreault 1990). The method has previously been used to advance the understanding of consumers' descriptions of their (positive and negative) experiences in retail contexts (e.g. Arnold et al. 2005; Jones 1999; Stein and Ramaseshan 2016). Thus, the method has been tested in similar settings before and proved reliable in cases when consumers are asked to generate own statements.

Overall, we have tried to replicate the method used in the 2006 study (Bäckström and Johansson 2006). In accordance to that earlier study, the part involving consumers was initially tested through a pilot study, making sure that the open-ended questions used to generate consumer experiences were relevant and could be understood by consumers. The current study is based on a consumer panel (provided by a market research company) consisting of roughly 60,000 members in all who are recruited by random sampling and using telephone calls as a means of contact. Sampling from the panel is done by stratified random samples with regard to age and gender. The sample used in this study consists of 270 persons. However, the number of younger consumers sampled from the consumer panel were assessed to be insufficient in the data-set. To compensate for that, we added data collected from 47 students, representing consumers of both sexes from all over Sweden

(currently students at Lund university), aged from 23 to 35 years. The empirical material consisting of consumer data amounts to 317 descriptions of positive experiences and 317 descriptions of negative experiences. These consumer statements refer to a wide variety of retail sectors, such as groceries, home decoration, clothing, and electronics. Instructions to the participants were the same in this study as in the study conducted in 2006, formulated as below.

> Describe your most recent in-store experience that you recall as especially positive/negative. Describe as explicitly as possible what was positive/negative and in what store you experienced this.

Whereas data from the 2006 study consist of handwritten texts – with positive and negative store experiences – supplied to us by consumers via postal mail, we collected the experience consumer text data in our present study digitally via a web site specifically designed for this purpose. In sum, the consumer samples in the two different studies are as similar as possible given the time span of ten years during which technological changes have been substantial.

The seven retail firms included in this study are active in the same categories, and are in most cases the same companies, as those in the 2006 study. If one of the companies in the former study was not available for inclusion in the present study, a competing firm was chosen. In both studies and all retail firms, we interviewed company representatives with good insights into and responsibility of creating consumer experiences in physical stores. All interviews were semi-structured and covered aspects such as the retailer's overall view on consumers' in-store experiences, and how they believe experiences in their stores are composed. The interviews also involved questions on how the retailers organize their store environments to evoke this kind of in-store experiences. In addition, the present study also embraces questions on channels besides the physical stores, and how retailers use other channels to create customer experiences. While serving as a guideline to the interviewer, we also asked the interviewees to – in their own words – tell how their company works to give consumers (positive) experiences in their physical stores. As for issues of reliability in this part of the study, the semi-standardized approach used made certain that interviewers could adjust to uncertainties and clarify the meaning of the questions, and hence, contextualize what the retailers were asked to convey. All interviews were conducted by the authors who are extensively skilled in interviewing managers, covering more than 35 years of combined experience as users of qualitative tools, and with an excess of 300 performed management interviews within different research projects. All retailer interviews each lasted between 1.5, and 2 hours and were later transcribed (word by word) and used in the analysis.

The analytical focus is here on attaining a thorough understanding of consumers' in-store experiences and their components. As in our 2006 study, the objective of the analysis of the consumers' statements is to identify the various store aspects which contribute in forming consumers' experiences. The initial analytic stage consisted of individual assessments, independently carried out by each of the two authors, of the substance and structure of the consumer statements. This entailed a process of making sense of and discerning essential patterns and themes in the texts. The process resulted in two separately composed lists of all store aspects involved in shaping the experiences described by the consumers. The lists were initially extensive but were gradually organized by sorting experiences into groups of themes and sub-themes. The next step in our analysis was merging the separate

lists into one coherent list. Using citations from the descriptions and comparing examples that we had found in the texts, we jointly decided on the final number of relevant themes. These included both aspects frequently mentioned in the texts and aspects that stood out (irrespective of frequency) in terms of being confirming (affirmative of expectations) or non-confirming (diverging from expectations). The retailer interviews were analyzed much in the same way as the consumer statements, in the sense that we first worked independently in identifying relevant themes and patterns, focusing on achieving an understanding of what experiences the retailers seek to provide for their customers. Specific attention was devoted to identifying the various means that retailers used to induce such experiences in the store environment. Throughout the analytical process, we searched for similarities as well as differences in the ways the respective retailers relate to in-store experiences.

We have tried to achieve overall high validity – i.e. whether the research has actually measured what it sets out to measure – by different ways of working within the methods used. In the part of the study containing consumer statements, the question of validity of the consumers' self-authored texts could be raised; how do the consumers know what actually influences them and are they here telling the truth? Using the CIT has advantages – see above – but it is possible to argue that the data generated does not 'mirror' what in fact influences consumers (cf. Miller and Glassner 2004, 126). However, we find that consumers in the present study, as consumers in previous research, tend to talk about variables acknowledged by previous research. Hence, the data reflects categories previously raised by numerous researches through the years. Also, as the same method was used in the follow-up study and the same categories of factors were raised by consumers, we think that we have a fair indication of validity in the consumer study.

In both studies, data was collected using the Swedish language. The researchers worked with the text in Swedish but quotations are used in English. Hence, translation to English had to be done in order to make quotations understandable in the academic journal context. A native English speaker, fluent in both Swedish and English, did the translation from Swedish to English. The translation was then checked by both researchers as to ascertain that the original meaning of the quotation was still there in the translated version.

Results

Experiences in physical stores: perspectives of the retailers

The question of how consumers' experiences are constituted is according to the retailers a complex story. Their descriptions support the notion of in-store experiences as multidimensional and contextual in nature (cf. Bäckström 2013; Verhoef et al. 2009). Working strategically with the retail environment to create a certain form of experience thus entails a number of challenges for retailers. In the section below, we outline some of these challenges and discuss how retailers use various store attributes to enhance positive in-store experiences.

Creating experiences in retail stores: meeting the demands of a new customer

The retailers commonly refer to in-store consumers of today as a new type of customer, a customer that they describe as 'competent,' 'knowledgeable,' and 'demanding.'

> Customers today are more updated and knowledgeable and because of that the demands on the personnel to add something more to the experience other than what the customer can read on the Internet is even greater now. (Book store)

> More is demanded in order to make the customer enter the store and to keep the customer in the store … and then you have to live up to the expectations, the expected shopping experience …Many know what they want, but increasingly customers coming to a store demand another type of service and experience. They expect shopping to be easy …Today many customers have done their homework on the Internet before coming to a store and know what to expect … and we need to meet them there, at that level of expectations. (Sport articles)

As the retailer citations above show, customers today come to the physical store with a different mindset compared to ten years ago. A common theme in the empirical data is the expressed need for developing and using staff competence to match the consumers' increased levels of knowledge. At the same time, while common references in the retailers' descriptions include aspects such as inspiration, service, and knowledge, also more rational values such as value for money, easy approach, and accessible store offerings are emphasized. Hence, enhancing customers' in-store experiences is to great extent about combining both emotional and rational elements, for example in terms of rapid provisioning of inspiration and knowledge:

> The customers demand answers very quickly and know what they want…Inspiration levels need to be super high … (…) And you need to adjust to that, adopt to it with lightning speed; what does this customer want? (Clothing)

Creating positive in-store experiences, from the retailers' point of view, becomes an issue of meeting such advanced and multilayered requirements. Many of the retailers stated that – as a consequence of this type of new customer demands – they are in the process of making large efforts to remodel their store offering, e.g. by implementing new store concepts and strategies, and increasing integration between stores and other channels.

As means of creating positive experiences for today's in-store customers, retailers use different strategies of which all involve a combination of multiple in-store aspects. This often includes traditional aspects such as personnel, design, atmosphere, display, selection, and price, but also new aspects, mainly in the form of technological solutions. Our findings, hence, give support to earlier studies in this research field that have emphasized the importance of a holistic approach when examining in-store experiences (e.g. Ballantine, Parsons, and Comeskey 2015; Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Spence et al. 2014). It is noteworthy that, with regard to traditional values such as personnel, design, and layout, retailers today work with these aspects in new ways. One example is how the clothing business retailer explains that nowadays design and visual merchandising is applied differently. One challenge of creating a store design that easily can change in accordance with rapidly shifting trends, is the simultaneous and increasing demand for sustainability. Moreover, products also need to be arranged in ways that enable the customer to quickly form an idea of the store's selection and what possible looks it can offer.

> We spend a lot of time working on how we hang up our clothes for customers to see. Ten years ago it was much more just hanging stuff on hangers; you hung things in the store and the customers saw everything sideways. Today, we try to show our stuff with the front facing out, giving the customer a view of the whole piece … with some accessories or a scarf and maybe a bag in the background …The customer then can see everything at the same time and goes; 'that's it, that's what I want!' … and the customer buys the whole outfit and they are done with their shopping in the ten minutes that was left of the lunchbreak. (Clothing)

Several of the retailers also emphasized the importance of creating a logical store layout, where customers can orient themselves easily without spending time searching for goods. This points at an interesting contradiction; while the retailers frequently emphasize the importance of providing outstanding service to satisfy today's customers, at the same time they also refer to a need for enabling quick store visits, and for dealing with increased automatization and insufficient resources. Dealing with such ambiguities is a central challenge for today's retailers and many use in-store technology to balance this. On the one hand, retailers use different technological solutions to enhance both the competence of their personnel and efficient customer services (e.g. digital scanning for stocktaking, automatic ordering of goods, check-out systems with direct connection to supply systems, and self-service systems). On the other hand, technological solutions are also applied to enhance customers' experience in more direct ways (e.g. digital screens, online store portals, and self-service checkout systems). While technological progress is currently a key issue for many of the retailers, much of it is nevertheless still work in progress. Interestingly, even though a majority of the retailers emphasize the importance of developing the stores' technological dimension, many of them stress that other areas are given priority – issues such as interaction between salespeople and customers, attracting customers to the store, or making all co-workers strive towards the same goals.

> The challenge is not to spend a lot of money on large technically advanced systems, the challenge is to think first and then act like co-workers in the different interactions we have with customers. That is what is difficult and challenging. (Home furnishing)

> Store unique planogram, we must admit, is nothing we have …We think it would be great but in the grand scheme of things, our challenge is still how to make the customers we have in the store to come and shop more often. (Grocery superstore)

To conclude, the retailers work strategically with a number of store aspects to enhance customers' in-store experiences. This means that they need to handle the challenges involved in combining different, even contradictory, aspects of the physical store, as well as synchronizing store offerings with their offerings in other channels. Interestingly, our results moreover show that the retailers commonly emphasize the importance of prioritizing more traditional values ahead of cutting-edge technology.

Experiences in physical stores: perspectives of the consumers

According to the consumers' descriptions of their in-store experiences, these are commonly formed by a number of different aspects, ranging from physical aspects (e.g. furnishing, layout, and selection), and social aspects (e.g. the personnel's behavior and/or competence), to atmospheric variables (e.g. music and scents). In this respect, our results support previous research that also has emphasized the combined effect of multiple store aspects when creating in-store experiences (e.g. Bäckström 2013; Ballantine, Jack, and Parsons 2010; Kent and Kirby 2009). The consumers' descriptions further indicate that interaction takes place between some of these aspects, which has bearing for how the store experience turns out:

> The store was full of people as it was the end of the sale but the personnel still acted very calmly, saying 'hello,' offering assistance and kept the store in order. I was also looking for an item from the new season that was not yet shown in the store but the personnel helped me by running down to the storage room and fetched it, even though a lot of people were in the store. That was a very positive experience. (Woman, 23)

An important component of the experience described above is the staff's ability to provide extraordinary service, even in the situation of a crowded store with lots of other customers. Such types of circumstances – e.g. many in-store customers during sales and the like, and the impression of tidiness in-store – may influence how customers perceive of and evaluate the behavior of the staff. This supports previous research which has shown that aspects of the store environment may influence how service is perceived (Baker, Grewal, and Parasuraman 1994), and further emphasizes the importance of acknowledging the multidimensional character of the store. Moreover, in our study, there was reoccurring consumer emphasis on the importance of maintaining the right balance between various dimensions; for example, the personnel's ability to sell *and* managing to be social at the same time, being helpful though not ingratiating, and so on. How well in-store staff are able to handle trade-offs – offering good advice without being pushy – was thus seen as important from the consumers' point of view:

> I was at Hemtex today and I guess I looked a bit confused. Then I was approached by a nice sales person who asked if she could be of any help … very polite and not 'pushy'. I got suggestions on a few alternatives but was left to make the decision on my own, that is, a not very 'pushy' sales person … that's good. (Man, 71)

The behavior of the personnel is by far the most central aspect according to the consumers' texts, with regard to both positive and negative experiences. The behavior of the staff influences customers' experiences in a variety of ways; for instance their willingness to help and their professional knowledge and skills, as well as their attitude and ways of treating in-store customers.

> I was helped in the store by nice sales attendants. The product I was looking for was not in stock but the staff ordered it and after only a few days I could pick it up in the store. (Woman, 67)

> One of the sales staff immediately caught sight of me and she asked if she could help me. She was very knowledgeable in her area and not at all like in many other places where they only care about selling. (Man, 59)

> I was ignored and had to wait for help in the store for a really long time. (…) I waited but finally gave up and left the store. (Woman, 45)

As the citations above show, a pleasant attitude, eagerness to offer assistance, and knowledge of the product or service selection are important dimensions as regards the behavior of personnel. These are all well-known aspects and have long been emphasized in earlier research. What is interesting though is the fact that even now, when retail stores offering spectacular design, customized music, and sophisticated technology are found in abundance, it is nevertheless more traditional aspects that stand out when the consumers describe positive store experiences. Our results are therefore supportive of the claim that service is an important competitive advantage in retail stores of today (cf. Bagdare 2013), whereas they go against research that suggest other aspects (e.g. store design) to be of higher significance (cf. Chang, Yan, and Eckman 2014).

In their descriptions, the consumers in our study often bring up store aspects that are well-documented in earlier works, relating to the personnel – as referred to above – but also to the selection of products and store layout (cf. Bäckström and Johansson 2006; Baker et al. 2002; Jones 1999; Verhoef et al. 2009). For example, the opportunity of establishing a good, clear selection overview, and the degree of ease with which the customer can find relevant products are also frequently mentioned:

> When I entered the store, I was meet by a spacious corridor with well-marked shelves. The store had soothing colour combinations and a simple and convenient way to find the products you wanted by searching on touch screens in the store. Good to be able to touch and squeeze the products, to get a feel for quality and so on. (Man, 28)

One important aspect of consumers' experiences involve handling store visits quickly and easily. Interestingly, when looking at consumer-related factors, references to the consumers' ability to do what they intended to when visiting a store, are the most prominent in their descriptions. However, and as the citation above also suggests, our results show that technological aspects, such as touch screens, may also play a central role in defining consumer experiences (cf. Pantano and Viassone 2015; Poncin and Mimoun 2014). As seen above, there is emphasis on both traditional store aspects (e.g. layout, colors, opportunity to feel products) and technology, suggesting that the combination of these may be valuable to consumers. Hence, while the consumer descriptions in our study to a great extent depict experiences created by store aspects which previously has been much studied, there is also reference in the material to more recently developed retail aspects. Furthermore, in the material it is shown that online channels may constitute an important aspect of consumer experiences also when visiting the physical store. For example, lack of congruence between different retail channels (with respect to price or selection) may generate negative experiences:

> I was in the Efva Attling jewellery store at Mall of Scandinavia to buy a particular set of earrings that I had seen on the Internet. I found them in the store but I was not allowed to buy them, as the sales person explained to me; they were for display only! The sales person was very kind and made nice gift-wrappings for the things I bought instead but it felt ridiculous not being able to buy what I had come for – and they [the earrings] were there, just in front of me! The sales person said that the earrings were not available anywhere in the whole country, but a week later they are still shown on the company's webpage! (Woman, 65)

However, surprisingly few references are made in the material to in-store technology and multichannel retailing, which suggest that other aspects are (still) considered more important in a physical store context.

Summing up, although our material shows that in-store technological solutions and online channels also influence consumers' experiences, we can conclude that the customers' experiences in physical stores to a substantial degree are made up of traditional aspects (e.g. personnel, layout, and atmosphere). Moreover, our results support the notion of consumers' in-store experiences as multidimensional in character, commonly involving multiple store aspects and embracing both rational and emotional dimensions (cf. Bäckström 2013; Petermans, Janssens, and Van Cleempoel 2013; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Spence et al. 2014; Yoon 2013). The findings presented here provide some further insights into how multiple store aspects contribute to the formation of in-store experiences, particularly by accentuating the interplay of several store aspects and the staff's ability to manage multiple dimensions.

Experiences in physical stores: a comparison between the perspectives of retailers and consumers

Above we have presented the retailers' and the consumers' respective views on in-store experiences. In the sections that follow, we compare these views, first focusing on the two different types of depictions in this study, and then relating these to the material in the 2006 article (see Bäckström and Johansson 2006).

Comparing retailers' and consumers' views of in-store experiences 2016

The overall impression when comparing the retailers' and the consumers' views on in-store experiences is the large degree of congruence present. Both retailers and consumers tend to emphasize traditional aspects, such as the behavior and attitude of the personnel, a logical store layout, and preconditions offered to customers in order for their store visit to become quick and smooth (see Table 1).

Moreover, both consumers and retailers refer to the physical store as a multidimensional place that must meet a number of different customer requests of both rational and emotional kinds. The retailers thus describe customers of today as 'a new type of customer' with more advanced demands, and the depiction given by the consumers strengthens this impression. According to the retailers, they also pay much attention to developing staff competence and statements by the consumers support the notion of in-store personnel as a crucial resource.

However, while the retailers emphasize technological developments, the consumers (with a few exceptions) hardly mention such issues. This does not, however, mean that technological solutions are not appreciated by consumers. A possible explanation for consumers not mentioning these aspects may be that these aspects do not readily come to mind for consumers when thinking about their in-store experiences. A methodological approach involving explicit questions as regards the importance of technological solutions would maybe have pointed results in another direction. However, what our results do indicate is that more traditional store aspects (e.g. personnel, layout, and atmosphere) are prioritized from a consumer point of view. Still, there is reason to note that also many of the retailers stressed the importance of more traditional values (e.g. staff competence and easily accessible products) and several of them explicitly stated that such aspects are considered ahead of sophisticated technology. With this in mind, also in these respects it is rather coherent views that are presented in the statements by both retailers and consumers.

Comparing the results of the 2016 study with the results of the 2006 study

Comparing the results presented in this study with the ones we found in our study in 2006, some notable differences can be discerned, in particular with regard to the retailers' input (see Table 2). Back in 2006, many of the retailers stated that they were in the process of reorganizing their store concepts as a means to meet growing requests for customer experiences. Interestingly, when we replicate our study ten years later, we meet very similar descriptions of the present situation. Several of the retailers are emphatic about reorganizing as response to new customer demands, with a focus on enhancing customers' in-store experiences. Noteworthy differences between the two studies (2006 and 2016 respectively) do, however, appear when looking specifically at the ways that retailers discuss restructure of their practices and store concepts.

To start with, the retailers provide a much more complex depiction in 2016 and all of them describe the average customer as a 'new type of customer,' and by that meaning more knowledgeable and demanding. Retailers of today refer to customers' demands as being more composite, accentuating the integration of emotional values (e.g. inspiration, enjoyment, and stimulation of different senses) and rational ones (e.g. quick and easy in-store

Table 1. A comparison between retailers' and consumers' views of in-store experiences 2016.

In-store experiences: Retailers in 2016	In-store experiences: Consumers in 2016
'Another important thing is … that it is about competent personnel. Here we have been a bit ignorant, we have been successful and have never really had to make an effort. Competence is very important, we really try to make an effort in creating competence in different forms. We have made several initiatives to make sure that we have competent personnel for the customer meeting.' (Home furnishing)	'I was buying jeans in a local store – not part of any big chain – and was treated very well and professionally by the sales person, getting good advice on what to buy. The positive thing was that the contact with the store attendant was just right, not too much and all the advice was very good and the staff seemed very knowledgeable.' (Man, 44)
'Yes, it is very much about that it has to be easy and not take very much time, it has to be inspiring …and the personnel has to be both service-minded and knowledgeable.' (Clothing)	'I was in a store shopping for a product that I had not pre-ordered and there was a long queue, still the queue decreased quicker than I thought (and faster than the promised queue time). The male sales person was nice and very efficient but still made eye contact and was friendly.' (Man, 33)
'We work in different store departments so what is presented needs to be within reach. Today's customer will not rummage a 750 square meter store in search for a necklace somewhere, they just won't look for it, so it needs to be close by, where the outfit itself is displayed because it fits the outfit and needs to be there, within close reach!' (Clothing)	'The clothes were sorted in a way that made it easy to find the right size …I did not have to ask anyone in the staff for sizes as I could easily see what was in stock.' (Man, 21)

Table 2. A comparison between retailers' views of in-store experiences in 2006 and 2016, respectively.

In-store experiences: Retailers in 2006	In-store experiences: Retailers in 2016
'In some places you can see signs and roped-off areas signaling "do not touch". We want our consumers to enter and to test and try out! They should feel at home.' (Home furnishing)	'We are trying to become better at listening to what the customers tell us. We try to be less ignorant than we were ten years ago … what do the customers actually experience in the store, how would the customers like it to be … no, as a customer you don't want to have to walk nine kilometres to get to the counters. Instead, we have to find a way to make a 25–30 min visit with us possible, rather than expecting everyone to want to stay an hour and a half.' (Home furnishing)
'We absolutely want (tailors) dummies with movements!' (Sports articles)	'We need to be clear in our message, what we stand for and what we want … in all channels! What is our standpoint and what do we have? In that respect we can hopefully meet customer expectations.' (Sport articles)
We want to stimulate as many senses as possible. That's why we also have included cosmetics and scents in our selection.' (Clothing)	'It is very important to have personnel that is service-minded, for real! And have a certain visual competence in merchandising, and are interested in fashion. That was really not the case if you look at our personnel in the past.' (Clothing)

visits, and value for money), thereby also the essentials of working strategically with the store as a multidimensional place (cf. Kent and Kirby 2009). The study shows that in 2016 retailers talk more about the need to consider multiple dimensions – within the context of the physical store as such but across retail channels as well.

Worth special mention is the fact that despite the vast technological advancements made over the last decade, retailers in the recent study focus more than expected on traditional values (e.g. personnel, store layout, and the like), also when compared to retailers in the 2006 study. Today retailers recognize that they need to work systematically with both advanced technological solutions and more basic values. It is fair to say, however, that an opposite trend is discernible in the 2016 material; in the former study (in 2006), retailers were emphatic about focusing on cutting-edge technology to meet increased customer demands for experiences. Presently, retailers instead accentuate the overall use of more traditional values for carrying out the same task (e.g. in terms of the behavior of personnel, rapid provisioning of products, and service). Moreover, while retailers back in 2006 focused on experiential dimensions (e.g. stimulation of senses, and opportunity to try out and test products in-store) in order to enhance customers' experiences, many retailers now emphasize the importance of rationality (e.g. opportunity to quickly gain overview of store selection, and rapid provisioning of staff service) when providing positive customer experiences in the store.

A comparison between the views of consumers in 2006 and 2016, respectively, gives a more unanimous description of important aspects. From both studies, we can conclude that traditional values, such as the behavior of personnel, a logical store layout, and easily accessible products, stand out in the consumers' statements. Nevertheless, there are also some differences as regards views presented in 2016 and in 2006; present-day, aspects more specifically related to online channels and in-store technology contribute to how in-store experiences are defined and generated, whereas those values were not in any way part of the picture back in 2006.

Concluding discussion

The retail sector has changed dramatically over the past decade, resulting in new shopping activities and altered conditions for the physical store. This study has improved our understanding of what this implies – from the view of retailers as well as consumers. We have shown that retailers of today face challenges in how to address new and more sophisticated demands from customers. Interestingly, while several of the retailers emphasize the need for new store concepts and strategies, as well as advanced technologies to meet such new demands, our results also show that more traditional values (e.g. personnel, layout, and display of products) are crucial in this regard. Hence, as shown here, efforts by retailers to remain competitive in an increasingly complex environment is not just about meeting up with cutting-edge technology and equipment; incorporated in this objective is also how to use traditional store attributes in new ways. When comparing to the views presented in 2006, today's retailers relate to consumers' in-store experiences in different ways. When we conducted our earlier study (Bäckström and Johansson 2006), retailers primarily emphasized the use of experiential values (e.g. advanced technology, and stimulation of senses) to enhance customers' in-store experiences. When we compare how retailers and consumers today give their views, we conclude that the depiction is rather uniform; both groups stress

that traditional values are an important part of in-store experiences (e.g. personnel, layout, and display of products). Our study show that in-store experiences are largely created by the same aspects today as ten years ago. This is interesting, not least in view of the extensive changes that retailing has undergone the last decade.

In previous research, extensive conceptual frameworks outlining various aspects that create in-store experiences have been presented (e.g. Grewal, Levy, and Kumar 2009; Puccinelli et al. 2009; Verhoef et al. 2009). However, there is a prevailing lack of empirical investigations into how different dimensions contribute in forming experiences. This study advances our theoretical understanding of consumers' in-store experiences and their components in different ways. First of all, it enhances our understanding of *what store aspects that are important for in-store consumers and how these aspects contribute in forming consumers' experiences in physical stores of today.* As presently many preconditions for retailing are subjected to major changes, to gain an updated understanding of issues such as the ones we here study is highly relevant. By replicating our study from 2006 we have performed a longitudinal study design. Using this approach, we have enhanced the understanding of how today's consumers experience and value retail store environments and also provided insights into what has changed and what has remained the same in such settings. As mentioned above, we find it particularly interesting that our study shows that consumers in 2016 – just as in 2006 – to a great extent emphasize traditional values. Even though references to technology and multichannel retailing are few in the consumers' descriptions, our results nevertheless provide some insights into the role of such aspects. Moreover, our study has explored both consumers' and retailers' perspectives and by including both these perspectives we have provided a comprehensive understanding of the recent years developments within retail store settings. As we have shown, comparing retailers views in 2006 with their views in 2016, there are considerable differences both as regards how they relate to their customers and how they organize their offerings.

Secondly, our study has also produced further knowledge as regards *the multidimensional character of the physical store*, particularly by providing new insights into how multiple store attributes influence in-store experiences. While the multidimensional character of the physical store is increasingly recognized (e.g. Bagdare 2013; Ballantine, Jack, and Parsons 2010; Kent and Kirby 2009; Sachdeva and Goel 2015; Verhoef et al. 2009), hitherto few have examined the ways in which multiple store aspects contribute in creating consumers' experiences, or what ways retailers use and combine different store aspects to form their offerings. Previous studies have more often focused on a minor number of store aspects and/or devoted attention mainly to the role of atmospheric variables (e.g. Eroglu, Machleit, and Chebat 2005; Hynes and Manson 2016; Jain and Bagdare 2011; Madzharov, Block, and Morrin 2015). By focusing on consumers' own descriptions of in-store experiences, we have shown that these often comprise a multitude of aspects and that the handling and balancing of several as well as differing aspects is crucial for retailers. Moreover, through this study, we also advance insights into how today's retailers relate to different store aspects. As we show here, one interesting finding is that aspects that for long have been well-established and recognized in many conceptual frameworks are now being used and applied in new ways. In our study, we show that retailers devote more to the efforts in the development of better skilled personnel, more focus on rational values, and take careful consideration of the ways in which products are organized and displayed. Our results suggest that it seems even more important now than before to understand the multidimensional character of the store.

Retail store offerings are thus becoming more and more complex; traditional values are used in new ways, and new dimensions – such as technological solutions – are added.

In addition, the findings of this paper also involve some managerial implications. Above all, we find that the retailers believe it is crucial to work systematically with multiple store aspects to meet more advanced customer demands. This involves salespeoples continuous handling of multiple store aspects; including for instance keeping the store tidy and well-stocked, offering competent assistance to in-store customers, as well as devoting detailed considerations to the ways in which products are displayed and organized in the store. Hence, as important as it is to keep up with technological development, we find that it seems ever-more important to also strengthen more basic values of physical stores, such as the personal interaction between sales staff and customers, and the employment of a store layout that is logic and easily approachable.

In our paper of 2006, we emphasized the need for retailers to devote careful attention to the level of service provided in the store. The findings of this paper indicate that retailers of today do work more focused with developing the competence of their personnel. Increasingly this competitive advantage visavis on-line shopping is recognized and efforts made to enhance this side of retailers' offers. However, the result of 2016's study reveals that consumers' service experiences still leave a lot to be desired. Consumers' descriptions thus point at the importance for retailers to devote further attention not only to enhancing salespeople's competence (e.g. in terms of their product knowledge, their ability to provide useful advices) but also to improving the quality of the personal interaction between salespeople and personnel.

Our recommendation for future research is to continue the exploration of multidimensional aspects of in-store experiences from a consumer viewpoint – for example by examining how multichannel retailing or in-store technology influence consumers' experiences in physical stores. Our study show that today's retailers relate to technological solutions in different ways and that the adoption of new technological developments for many retailers is still limited or in very early stages. Hence, we encourage future research to further examine how technological solutions may be used to enhance consumers' in-store experiences.

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